

system that people can then add (or remove) features to as they see fit? This is something Microsoft has, in fact, gone some way towards addressing with its approach to Vista. Unlike XP and previous Windows releases, Microsoft opted for a multi-tiered strategy for Vista, with several different versions each aimed at a particular user base with specifically tailored features. In this way, a Vista Business user isn't paying for media features he or she won't need, for example, while home users won't find their PCs weighed down by business-related tools and utilities that are completely useless to them.

This time around, Microsoft even produced a fully stripped-down edition of Vista — Windows Vista Home Basic, which comes without many of the big features (such as Media Center and the Aero interface) and fewer hidden ones. See page 14 for a more in-depth comparison of the various versions of Vista.

Hide and seek

What's surprising about some of Vista's 'hidden' features is that they're hidden at all. Take handwriting and speech recognition,

Vista's hidden flaws

While there's plenty to like about Vista — the best version of Windows so far — a certain amount of criticism has been levelled against it. Many complaints involve performance issues, while other objections centre on the limited functionality of many of Vista's built-in features. Thankfully, whether you're looking for a speed

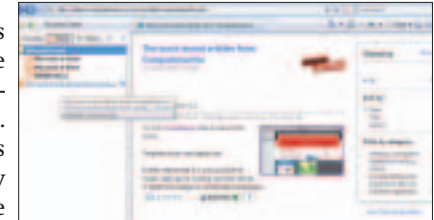


Vista includes some great features, but occasionally there are better alternatives available, such as Paint.net

increase or you'd like to fill some of the holes in Vista's armoury of applications and utilities, there's a high chance you'll find a setting you can tweak or a third-party tool you can use instead. We're not saying Vista's perfect; there are still a few minor problems here and there, but by following our advice and by using some of the software on our free CD, many of these can be quickly laid to rest.

for example. A few years ago, these would have been higher-profile selling points for Vista. Admittedly, the days when controlling a PC by voice or penstroke alone was the Holy Grail of computing have perhaps gone, but that doesn't make either feature any less useful for those who prefer — or physically require — an alternative to traditional mouse and keyboard input. Indeed, the inclusion of such features within Windows can save you a considerable sum of cash. It's possible, for example, to buy a standalone speech recognition program from a third-party developer, such as Dragon Naturally Speaking 10. Such a program might have certain advantages — it might contain better tutorials, for example — But is it worth approximately Rs. 10, 600, when a perfectly serviceable alternative comes built into your PC?

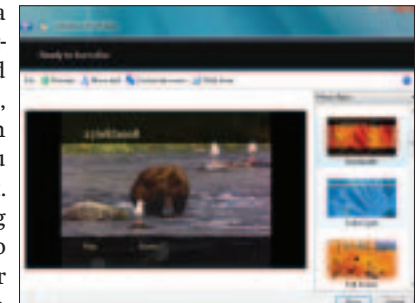
The same can be said for many of the other tools that appear when you give Vista a shake. Everyone has a hectic schedule nowadays, and thankfully Vista introduces, for the first time, a built-in calendar to ensure you never miss an appointment. Previously, anyone wanting to use their computers to keep an electronic diary or to-do list would have to invest in expensive approximately Rs. 7, 200 and up)



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Using Parental Control, it is easy to place restrictions on how certain users are able to work with Windows



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